The Mountaintop

By Katori Hall

CAMAE: **(Pg 14-16)** Walkin' will only get you so far, Preacher Kang.

KING: We're not just walking**:** we're marching.

CAMAE: Whatever it is, it ain't workin'.

KING: It doesn't work when you have trifling Negroes who call themselves using a peaceful protest to get a free color television. Just last week me and my men organized a march for –

CAMAE: Them garbage men?

KING: *(correcting)* Yes, the sanitation workers. Must have been thousands upon thousands of people there. Well, we hadn't walked but one block before we heard the sound of glass breaking. I was swept up in a tornado of arms, legs, coughing mace. I didn't wanna leave those people, Camae . . . but my men pushed me into a passing car, and . . . I looked through that back window and saw such blessed peace descend into chaos *(beat)* Don't they know . . . We're marching for a living wage . . . not a damn color TV! It just gives these police an excuse to shoot innocent folks. Like that boy . . . that sixteen-year-old boy they shot. *(quietly to himself)* Larry Payne. I'll never forget his name . . . After the march, the papers called me 'Chicken a la King." Said I was a Commie coward that leaves other people to clean up my mess. "Martin ***Loser*** King . . "

CAMAE: Seem like times been a little rough on you. Folk done got tired through, Preacher Kang. *(sighs)* Like I say, walkin' will only get us so far –

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *April 3, 1968 -- the last day of the Reverend Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr's life.*
ACTRESS: *He's at the Lorraine Hotel, room 306 in Memphis, Tennessee, working on yet another powerful speech and orders a simple cup of coffee from room service.*
ACTOR: *But with his coffee arrives a mysterious maid, bringing him much more than a late-night beverage.*
TOGETHER: *The Mountaintop by Katori Hall*

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KING: **(Pg 16 – 19)** *(annoyed)* Well, killin' will get you hung. So what are we supposed to do?

CAMAE: I got a plan. But . . . I'm just a woman. Folk'll never listen to me.

KING: So if you were me, what would you do?

CAMAE: *(stands on one of the beds. Throughout her speech King is her congregation, egging her on with well-timed sayings like, Well! Preach! or Make it plain! Camae with a King voice)* We have gathered here today to deal with a serious issue. How do we deal with the white man? I have told you that the white man is our brother. And he should be treated as such. But it is hard to do this when our brother beats his fist upon our flesh. When he greets us with 'Nigger' and 'Go back to Africa.' We have walked. We have been drowned by hoses. Our dreams washed away. We have been bitten by dogs. Our skin forever scarred by hatred. To this I say, my brethren, a new day is coming. We are fighting to sit at the same counter, but why, my brothers and sisters? We should build our own counters. Our own restaurants. Our own neighborhoods. Our own schools. The white man ain't got nothin' I want. *(steps down).* Well, that's what I would say . . . if I was you.

KING: White folks don't seem to want to listen. *(beat)* Sometimes I wonder where they get this hatred of us from. So many white people hate us, Camae. Bombin' folks' homes. Shootin' folks . . . blowin' up children.

CAMAE: Last time I heard you was preachin' 'everybody the same.' Negro folk. White folk. We all alike. What one thing we all got in common? *(beat)*

KING: *(searches hard to come up with an answer)* We scared, Camae. Scared of each other. Scared of ourselves. Scared of losin' somethin' that they've known their whole lives. Fear makes us human. We all need the same basic things. A hug. A smile. *(beat-- looks her up and down)* Not too many maids spouting off well-formed diatribes like that. You made it sound real pretty, but nobody can make it pretty like me. I've been doing this for years, darlin'. Gonna be doin' it till the day I die. *(begins to get short of breath)*

CAMAE: **(Pg 21)** Speak by love, die by hate. *(pause)* We all have weaknesses, Preacher Kang. I'm sho' you got yo' own. *(beat)* For what it worth, I know God like you. ***She*** told me She like you. **(Pg 22-23)** *(King stumbles holding his chest)* You awright?

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KING: I can't breathe . . . can't, can't breathe . . .

CAMAE: Micahel? MICHAEL!! Michael, just breathe!

KING: *(soto voice)* can't . . . can't . . . *(the thunder in King's heart stops. Silence. They breathe together slowly together)* You called me Michael . . . How would you know that?

CAMAE: Calm down, Preacher Kang. I didn't mean to call you out you name.

KING: But that is my childhood name. How do you know my real name? *(backs away from her; softly)* So, you one of them, huh?

CAMAE: I'm so sorry. I never wanted to do this.

KING: *(shaking his head)* A spy. Get out! I said GET OUT. *(enraged, King searches for bugs. He yells yelling at no one in particular)* What, y'all think you can trap me! Record me with a woman! Well, you're not going to catch me!

CAMAE: Preacher Kang, calm down!

KING: You think you can break me! Well, you can't break me! *(Grabs Camae by her arm and pulls her towards the door)*

CAMAE: Preacher Kang, you're hurting me!! You wrong! You wrong!

KING: **(Pg 24-25)** How do you know so much about me! WHO IN THE HELL ARE YOU?

CAMAE: *(gives him a look as if she is communicating to him telepathically)*

KING: You're. An. Angel? Wow. An angel?

CAMAE: Yes. I'm here to take you to the other side.

KING: *(Suddenly very serious)* I'm not going to hell, am I?

CAMAE: Naw! Heaven is we're we headed. *(beat)* Sorry I called you Michael. Not too many folk prolly know that 'about you. God said yo' Christian name calms you.

KING: You're really an angel? But . . but why'd God send you? *(pause)* Why He -

CAMAE: She!

KING: ***She*** send you?

CAMAE: **(Pg 26-27)** Believe you me I ain't want this job. First day? Bring you over? The Kang? But God been getting' these prayers from a littl'un named Bunny. *(in a little child's voice)*

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'Please, God, don't let my daddy die alone.' *(in her regular voice)* Well, it just 'bout broke my heart. I just had to come . . .

KING: You know her nickname . . . my sweet Bernice. My baby girl spoke to you?

CAMAE: Her prayers are powerful. I don't like chiren too much, but she . . . she something.' *(pause)* Look, I know you afraid, Preacher Kang . . . You should be.

KING: *(with total calm)* You talk about fear, Camae, well . . . I have felt fear. Felt it even when I stood in front of my own congregation. Sunday mornings have been the mornings I am most afraid. 'Cause in this country, in America, the tall tree is felled first. Tall trees have more wood to burn, Camae. We are the sacrifice.

CAMAE: You been knowin' I was comin', haven't you?

KING: Yes. In my darkest hours, I've even prayed for you. Been so many death threats that some nights I have asked God, 'Please just get it over with.' Fear, Camae, is my best friend. Cause I know if I'm still afraid, then I'm still alive.

CAMAE: Tomorrow. When it time, you gonna have to take my hand.

KING: Tomorrow? But I'm not ready to die. I still got so much work to do. *(picks up papers from his desk and reads aloud)* Why America is going to hell –

CAMAE: Preacher Kang, you gone have to put that down.

KING: *(in his "King voice")* A country that sends its boys to bathe little-bitty brown babies in the blood of our greed is headed for a crossroads of conscience . . . America, my sweet America, is surrounded by rising water, waiting to drown. But the children of the Nile will rise, they will RISE! Can I get an Amen?

CAMAE: AMEN!!

KING: I need to be alone to finish my sermon so. . . you gone have to fly on away. *(returns to his sermon)* **(Pg 28)** If only they could see that love is the most radical weapon there is. But they won't listen. Even my own men – 'You splittin the movement, Martin! You can't focus on war, and poverty, and Negroes!' *(to Camae)* Just a little more time, just a little bit more . . .

CAMAE: -- this hard on me.

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KING: Hard on ***YOU***? What about on me? On my family? On the movement? HAS GOD THOUGHT ABOUT THAT?!

CAMAE: **(Pg 29-30)** What about yo' mens? Can't they see it through?

KING: They don't dream the same dreams I do, Camae. They think I'm crazy to dream this big. Bbut how can we fight the war in Vietnam but not the war against Negroes in our streets? How can we try to put a man on the moon, but not feed starving children in Mississippi? There's just so much I gotta do. So much I haven't accomplished.

CAMAE: Well, let me tell you something, Preacher Kang. Like most men, you ain't gone be able to finish what you started.

KING: My house has been bombed! I have been pelted wit' rocks. Spit at. Pummelled. I have been stabbed in my chest. And I walked away. Alive! Tell me I ain't got favor wit' God.

CAMAE: You just a man, baby. You're not God, though some folk'll say you got mighty close. Honey, I know all about your trials and tribulations. I done read yo' blessings file. It bigger than yo' FBI file and bigga than the Bible. I know it might be hard for you to leave this life . . . But you 'bout to burn out, stuperstar. You gone need to pass off that baton.

KING: **(Pg 35)** Camae? . . . . *(beat. King dissolves into tears)* I've been prayin' that it would stop. *(Camae comforts him)* That it would all go away. I never wanted to do this. I just wanted to be a minister in my small church. That was enough . . .

CAMAE: But God had bigger plans for you. **(Pg 36-37)** Powerful the man that get more done dead than alive.

KING: I don't want to be a martyr.

CAMAE: But the suit fits you well. Tomorrow, you'll be a man-made martyr. A saint!

KING: Don't call me that. I'm a sinner, not a saint. I'm not deservin' of the title.

CAMAE: You think I am? Honey, I've robbed. I've cheated. I've failed. But what I'm ashamed of most is, I've hated. Hated myself. Sacrificed my flesh so that others might feel whole again. I thought it was my duty. Last night, in the back of an alley I breathed my last breath. A man clasped his hands 'round my throat. I stared into his eyes and saw the hell this world had put him through. The time he saw his father hang a man. The time he saw his mother raped. I

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felt so sorry for him. I saw what the world had done to him, and I still couldn't forgive. I hated him. When I passed to the other side, God stood before me. I was just weepin' at her feet. Beggin' her not to throw me down. All that sinning.' All that hatred in my heart. But I heard Her say. "I got a special task for you and if you complete it, all your sins will be washed away." And my task was you. You have the biggest heart I done ever knownt. You have the strength to love those who could never love you back. If I had just a small fraction of the love you have for this world, then maybe, just maybe I could become half the angel you are.

KING: Will I die at the hands of a white man, too?

CAMAE: Yes. Speak by love. Die by hate.

KING: **(Pg 38-41)** Is the future as beautiful as you?

CAMAE: Yes . . . and it's as ugly as me, too. It might break your heart.

KING: I wanna see it. I will go willingly into your arms, Camae. If you just let me see these dreams I'll never ever see.

CAMAE: *(considers, then)* Let's take you to the mountaintop.

(King nods, gulping back tears – He sees and reacts to the following as Camae narrates – she exits scene during the last refrain, leaving King to speak his last passage alone)

The Prince of Peace. Shot.
His blood stains the concrete outside
Room 306
A worker wipes away the blood but not before
Jesse baptizes his hands on the balcony
The baton passes on.
Memphis burning, DC burning
Cities burning, Vietnam burning
Coffins coming home
Another Kennedy killed
The baton passes on

Robben Island sets Mandela free
Rodney King screams:
'Can't we all just get along?'
Black raised fists
I'm black and I'm PROUD!
The baton passes on

Drive-bys, Iraq,
NBA, high-paid slaves
Amerian flags
And black presidents!
The baton passes on

The Towers sigh
The world turns gray
September 11th
One bright morning day
The baton passes on

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KING: **(Pg 42)** *(alone to the audience)* Well . . . nobody said it was gonna be easy. The baton may have been dropped. But ***anyone*** can pick it back up. This baton is no longer the burden my image can bear. For you are the climbers, the new carriers of the cross. I beg you, don't give in and toss it off. The Promised Land is so close, and yet so far away . . .

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